before the huge crowds who had gathered outside Tiananmen, the Gate of Heavenly Peace, about the never allowing the people of China to be slaves again.

China under the iron-fisted, communist rule of Mao Zedong was never a truly free nation but he did manage to unify the country in a way Chiang Kai-shek had never been able to. While China's new rulers recognized the independence of communist-ruled Mongolia, the clerical state of Tibet had to be brought under the control of the Chinese central government.

Though the United States may never formally have recognized Tibet as part of the Republic of China, as was claimed by successive Chinese governments, Washington treated it as such so as not to upset its relations with Chiang Kai-shek. But the American attitude was to change dramatically as the Communists were gaining ground in China. Already in January 1949, when it was becoming obvious that the days of Chiang's KMT government were over, the American ambassador to India suggested to the State Department in Washington that a review of its Tibet policy would be appropriate. In particular, the ambassador proposed that if Mao Zedong and his communists succeeded in taking control of China, the United States should be prepared to treat Tibet as independent, 'If the Communists gain control of China proper, Tibet will be one of the few remaining non-Communist bastions in Continental Asia. Outer Mongolia is already detached. Communist influence is strong in Burma and Communists are infiltrating Sinkiang [Xinjiang] and Inner Mongolia. Tibet will accordingly assume both ideological and strategic importance.'[95]

On 17 November 1950, the fourteenth Dalai Lama, then 15 years old, was formally enthroned as the ruler of Tibet—but his reign was not going to be a peaceful one. Prior to his enthronement, on 7 October, communist troops had crossed the River Jinsha and fought their first and perhaps most decisive battle with the tiny, ill-equipped Tibetan army. About 5,000 Tibetan soldiers are believed to have died in the fighting, which amounted to wholesale slaughter.

Ngapoi Ngawang Jigme, a governor who had been captured by the Chinese, was sent to Lhasa to negotiate with the Dalai Lama. After several months of deliberations, on 23 May 1951, Jigme signed the 17-point agreement for 'the Peaceful Liberation of Tibet' in Beijing. It was the first time, and long before Hong Kong reverted to Chinese rule in 1997, that China promised a model based on 'one country, two systems'. The